

Coco Gauff became the first American to claim the prestigious season-ending WTA Finals crown since Serena Williams in 2014.



FIVE TAKEAWAYS FROM THE WTA FINALS

A new Big Four in women's tennis

A new Big Four has emerged in women's tennis, led by the clear No. 1, Aryna Sabalenka. Sabalenka — the champion at the Australian Open, US Open, Cincinnati, and Wuhan and semifinalist in the WTA Finals, where she lost to Coco Gauff. The Belarusian Basher dethroned Iga Świątek, who still managed an impressive season, capturing her fourth French Open title, along with victories in Rome, Madrid, Indian Wells and Qatar.

Despite not winning a Major this year, rising stars Gauff and Zheng Qinwen secured their place in the Big Four during the WTA Finals in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia.

Gauff became the first American to claim the prestigious season-ending crown since Serena Williams in 2014 and the only player to defeat both Sabalenka and

Świątek in the same tournament this year. Zheng had a breakthrough campaign, reaching the Australian Open final, winning China's (and Asia's) first singles gold medal at the Paris Olympics, and narrowly losing to Gauff in the Riyadh final.

Gauff and Zheng shine in the final

The intriguing final in Riyadh showcased a thrilling battle between 'The Great American Hope' and 'The Great Chinese Hope'. The player who idolised Serena versus the player who said she strives to play like Serena. "The best competitor on the women's tour," according to esteemed coach and *Tennis Channel* analyst Paul Annacone against a "cut-throat" rival, according to No. 8 Emma Navarro.

Gauff's 3-6, 6-4, 7-6 (2) over Zheng at Riyadh was the youngest final with a combined age of 42 years and 271 days since Maria

Sharapova upset Serena in 2004. Gauff also became only the fourth American to win this title before the age of 21, joining teenage champions Serena, Chris Evert, and Tracy Austin.

How Gauff prevailed

The match was filled with twists and turns, but the more consistent player — especially in critical games — eventually emerged victorious. Zheng, who had been in red hot form with a 31-5 record since Wimbledon, raced to a 6-3, 2-0 lead. Behind 2-3, the younger but more experienced American broke Zheng's potent serve three consecutive times to seize the second set, 6-4.

The Chinese, who led the Riyadh field with 35 aces and 54 per cent of her first serves unreturned before entering the final, won just three service points during the turnabout. Another key: Gauff improved her court position in rallies from six to